



CHANGED: AFTER THE END

A Post-Apocalyptic Furry Science-Fiction

*Being a True and Faithful Account of the World That Came After, and the Terrible,
Wonderful Thing Found Sleeping in the Ruins*

@SIMOTHEFINLANDIZED

Paul Palazzolo · Originally 2024 · Remastered 2026



Changed: After the End

Copyright © 2024, 2026 by Paul Palazzolo (@SimoTheFinlandized)

All rights reserved.

This is a work of speculative fiction. All characters, nations, theological arguments, and world-historical events depicted herein are products of the author's imagination. The Holy Columbian Confederacy, the Great Latex Plague, and the peoples of post-Plague North America are fictional constructs. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, or to actual governmental bodies, surviving or collapsed, is purely coincidental.

The Furry community depicted in this work is treated with the respect it deserves.

Originally written 2024. Remastered edition, 2026.

CONTENTS

PROLOGUE: THE WORLD THAT WASN'T

PART THE FIRST: THE CONFEDERACY

PART THE SECOND: THE AGE OF RECOVERED WONDERS

PART THE THIRD: THE DARKER SIDE

EPILOGUE: WHAT THE CHILDREN ARE TOLD

*For the ones who woke up different and had to figure out what to do with
that. And for the ones who woke up the same and had to figure out the
same thing.*

» 6 □ 2 □ 2 » 6 □ 2 □ 2 » 6

*"The past is a foreign country. They do things differently there." — L.
P. Hartley*

*"The past is also radioactive, booby-trapped, and home to at least one
thing you really shouldn't have touched." — Common saying, Holy
Columbian Confederacy, circa 2700 AD*

» 6 □ 2 □ 2 » 6 □ 2 □ 2 » 6

PROLOGUE: THE WORLD THAT WASN'T

Here is the thing about civilisations: they are much more fragile than they look while you're living inside one.

This is not a new observation. The people of Rome, near the end, probably noticed that things were getting quieter than they used to be. The Maya watched the cities empty out one generation at a time. Every civilisation that has ever ended has ended in the presence of people who thought, right up to a certain point, that it probably wasn't going to. That's not stupidity — that's just what it's like to be inside something enormous, where the edges are too far away to see.

The civilisation of the twenty-first and twenty-second centuries was no different.

It ended in stages, the way a fire goes out: first the great bright burning, then the long slow dimming, then the dark. There were the climate shifts, which they'd been warned about and had half-addressed and had then argued about addressing until the addressing window closed. There were the resource wars, which polite people called something else. There were the pandemics —

several of them, ordinary ones, handled with varying degrees of competence — and then, in the spring of 2143, the one that wasn't ordinary at all.

The Great Latex Plague.

The name sounds almost funny, which is something people have pointed out for five hundred years, because it is the name that stuck and the name reflects the peculiar colour of the substance that appeared on the skin of those infected in the early stages, before the changes began. History is full of dignified names for undignified things. Historians, like everyone else, are just doing their best.

What the Plague did, precisely, remains a subject of scholarly debate in the academies of the post-Plague world, because the scholars of the post-Plague world do not have access to the pre-Plague research institutions that might have been able to tell them. What is known, from the survival accounts and the fragmentary records that were preserved through the dark centuries, is this:

The Plague was a pathogen unlike anything that had been catalogued. It did not kill the way diseases kill. It *changed* things. At the molecular level, at the cellular level, at every level you care to name — it reached into the instructions that said *make a human* and it rewrote them, thoroughly and permanently, into something different.

Some of those infected died. A significant portion of them died. The Plague was not, in this respect, merciful.

But some of them didn't.

Some of them *changed*.

The Changed — who would eventually call themselves the Furies, partly in reclamation of a word that had existed before the Plague with a very different meaning, and partly because a people needs something to call itself and they had earned the right to choose — the Changed were what the Plague made when it decided not to kill. They were, in the most literal sense of the term, animal-human hybrids: bipedal, sapient, capable of speech and reason and art and agriculture and all the things that *sapient bipedal beings* tend to do when you give them enough centuries. But carrying, woven permanently into their biology, the traits of the animal the Plague had decided they would be.

Nobody got to choose which animal.

This is one of the things that distinguished the Changed from the humans who survived unchanged: the uncertainty of it. A Changed parent could not reliably predict what their children would look like, because the Plague's logic — if it had logic — was its own. Families that had been entirely vulpine for three generations would produce a child with the broad shoulders and dark pelt of a bear lineage. Brothers would grow up one as a wolf and one as a rabbit. The Plague had, apparently, a sense of humour, or at least a complete indifference to human expectations.

The unchanged humans, whom the Changed sometimes called the *Pures* and sometimes called the *Straights* and sometimes called just *people*, depending on the region and the century and the current state of whatever fragile arrangement the two populations had worked out with each other — the unchanged humans numbered roughly a third of the post-Plague population, by the estimates of the scholars of 2700 AD, though the estimates varied considerably depending on who was doing the counting and what they were counting.

Five hundred and fifty-seven years after the Plague, the world looked like this:

North America was a continent of kingdoms and territories, each carved from the ruins of something larger, each with its own theology and flag and opinion about every other kingdom and territory. The coastlines were largely uninhabited — the sea-level changes of the previous centuries had rearranged them in ways that made settlement difficult, and most of the old coastal cities were ruins at best and reefs at worst. The interior was alive.

There were tribal peoples in the Pacific Northwest: mostly Changed, mostly lupine and ursine lineages, following seasonal migrations the way their ancestors had before the coming of the industrial age, which they remembered in their oral histories as *the Long Loud Time* — an era of noise and light and incomprehensible speed, ended, and not entirely mourned.

There were the iron-age kingdoms of the Great Lakes region, settled agrarian societies with smiths and mills and appointed councils and the kind of calendar disputes that only arise in societies with enough stability to care about when, precisely, to plant the grain. Mixed populations, Changed and Pure, with varying degrees of formal equality and informal tension.

There were the nomadic federations of the Great Plains — the most diverse in composition, Pure and Changed and the occasional *Partial* (the children of mixed lineages, who occupied their own complicated social category) moving together across the grasslands with a pragmatism born of shared necessity.

And there, in the Deep South, anchored to the land that had once been Mississippi and Alabama and Tennessee and the surrounding territories, was the Holy Columbian Confederacy.

This is where our story begins.

» 6 □2 □2 » 6 □2 □2 » 6

PART THE FIRST: THE CONFEDERACY

CHAPTER I: A NATION UNDER GOD, MORE OR LESS

The Holy Columbian Confederacy was founded in the year 2389 — two hundred and forty-six years after the Plague, three hundred and eleven years before the events of this account — by a consortium of Evangelical-Christian communities that had survived the collapse in relatively good order by virtue of already being organised, already having food networks, and already possessing a theological framework for understanding catastrophe that, while not entirely correct in its particulars, was at least functional as a coping mechanism.

They named the Confederacy after Christopher Columbus, which was either a tribute to the spirit of exploration or an impressive failure of self-awareness, depending on your perspective. They established an elected Emperor — elected by a council of dukes and kingdom-representatives, serving for life, a compromise position between the monarchical instincts of some constituent

kingdoms and the democratic instincts of others that satisfied no one completely but everyone tolerably, which is approximately the best outcome you can hope for from constitutional design.

By 2700, the Confederacy was home to roughly four million people, of whom perhaps sixty percent were Pure humans and forty percent were Changed. The relationship between these populations was, in the technical language of the Confederacy's own legal documents, *a matter of ongoing governance*, which is the way that official documents describe things that are very complicated and slightly shameful.

The Changed had rights. The extent and reliability of those rights depended on which of the Confederacy's eleven constituent kingdoms you happened to be standing in. In the Kingdom of New Tennessee, a Changed citizen could own property, testify in court, and hold certain civic offices, and had been able to do so for over a century. In the Duchy of Lower Carolina, the legal status of the Changed had been debated, amended, re-debated, and amended again so many times that even the duchy's own magistrates occasionally had to refer to the current edition of the legal code to remember where things stood.

This is mentioned not to condemn but to describe. The Confederacy was what it was: a society built by survivors on top of ruins, carrying its virtues and its failures in equal measure, as all societies do.

Emperor Josiah IV, the ruler in question for the year 2700, was by general consensus a reasonable man — which in his position meant he was the kind of person who could hold twelve contradictory pressures simultaneously without resolving them prematurely, which is perhaps the most accurate definition of governance that exists.

He had, that spring, authorised an expedition.

» 6 □2 □2 » 6 □2 □2 » 6

CHAPTER II: THE EXPEDITION

The expedition was Commander Adaline Voss's idea, though she would have said it less dramatically than that. What she would have said, and did say, to the Imperial Logistics Council, was: "The old maps show significant pre-Plague infrastructure in the northern territories that we haven't surveyed since the Second Clearing. The Plague's effects on pre-Plague structures are not uniform. Some of those structures may still be intact. Intact pre-Plague structures may contain materials of value. I would like six months, a company of forty, and a modest provisioning budget, and I will bring back a survey."

She got the six months and thirty-two people and a provisioning budget the Council described as *modest* and she described as *technically more than zero*.

Adaline Voss was forty-one years old, a Pure human, a veteran of three border campaigns on the northern edge of the Confederacy's territory, and possessed of the particular kind of patience that is not passive — the patience of someone who has learned that most things worth having require a longer timeline than people initially estimate. She had a scar along her left jaw from the second border campaign that she had stopped noticing in mirrors about fifteen years ago, and a tendency to make decisions quickly and justify them slowly, which her subordinates found alternately reassuring and nerve-wracking.

She had also, which was relevant to the present undertaking, a working relationship with a Changed guide named Ryker.

» 6 □2 □2 » 6 □2 □2 » 6

Ryker's full name, in the naming tradition of his lineage, was Ryker-of-the-Ash-Ridge-Clan, but he went by Ryker because the full form struck most Pure humans as cumbersome and he had stopped caring about correcting them around the age of twenty-two. He was thirty-five now, fox-lineage — burnt-orange pelt with white underfur, ears that moved with his attention in ways he'd long since stopped trying to suppress, a tail he'd learned to navigate through doorframes with the automatic grace of someone who has spent a lifetime doing it. He was, professionally, a pathfinder and

interpreter, working the borderlands between the Confederacy and the Great Lakes territories where the knowledge of both regions was genuinely useful and neither side owned him.

He had worked with Adaline on two previous surveys, neither of which had produced anything particularly interesting. He trusted her with his safety to the degree that trust is available in professional relationships, which is more than most people give credit for.

When she'd sent him the expedition brief, he'd read it twice, gone for a long walk to think about it, and then sent back a reply that read: *I'm in. Northern Ohio or further?*

She'd written back: *Louisville. And further north, if Louisville gives us something.*

He'd stared at that for a while.

Louisville was old, as pre-Plague cities went. Old enough that the ruins had been given back to the forest, more or less — the skeletal frames of enormous structures rising from the canopy, the old roads cracked and grass-covered, the whole thing having acquired over five centuries the ambiguous quality of a place that has been abandoned long enough to feel historical rather than merely dead. Survey teams had passed through Louisville twice in the last hundred years. Neither report had mentioned anything unusual.

What neither report had mentioned, which Adaline had found in an even older survey she'd dug out of the Imperial Archive's basement, was a reference to a *sealed subterranean structure* in the old city's eastern district. The reference was brief — a footnote in a report from 2586, written by a surveyor who had noted it and then, apparently, decided it was outside the scope of his assignment.

Adaline had decided it was entirely within the scope of hers.

Alright, Ryker had written back. *I'll be at the northern gate before dawn, the second week of April.*

He was there before dawn. He was always early. He had a reputation to maintain.

» 6 □2 □2 » 6 □2 □2 » 6

CHAPTER III: WHAT THEY FOUND IN THE RUINS OF LOUISVILLE

The forest had taken Louisville back with the slow, methodical enthusiasm that forests bring to anything that stops resisting them.

The expedition entered the old city from the south, picking their way along what had once been a major road and was now a corridor of cracked asphalt hosting a thriving population of wildflowers. The building skeletons around them were draped in vine and moss, their windows long since empty, their interiors

colonised by birds and small mammals that watched the expedition pass with the mild curiosity of creatures who had never been taught to fear humans.

This was the thing about the post-Plague world that the expedition members who hadn't grown up in its northern territories had to adjust to: the *quiet*. Not silence — the birds were extremely vocal, and the wind through the ruins produced an constant low harmonic that Brother Ezekiel, the expedition's monk-scholar and designated note-taker, kept trying to describe in his journal and kept failing to capture adequately. But the absence of the sounds of human industry, of machinery and traffic and the ten thousand noises that had once constituted the ambient noise of a city — that absence had its own texture, and walking through Louisville you felt it the way you feel a gap where a tooth used to be.

Brother Ezekiel Marsh was thirty years old, technically assigned to the expedition as its theological advisor and practically functioning as its most compulsive documentarian. He was thin and bookish in the way of people whose bodies have spent most of their time being ignored in favor of their minds, wore the practical grey robes of the Order of the Renewed Covenant with the slightly distracted air of someone who had put them on this morning and immediately stopped thinking about them, and carried in his pack, alongside the standard survival gear, four blank journals and twice the standard allocation of ink.

He had spent his career in the Imperial Archive, cataloguing the fragments of pre-Plague knowledge that survived in the Confederacy's collections — things rescued from the ruins by the first post-Plague generations, preserved with varying degrees of care, understood with varying degrees of accuracy. He had a gift for the fragmentary: for looking at an incomplete record and inferring, carefully and honestly about the limits of the inference, what the missing parts had probably contained.

He was, in other words, precisely the kind of person you wanted along when you expected to find something old and unknown.

On the fourth day of their time in Louisville, Ryker found the door.

» 6 □2 □2 » 6 □2 □2 » 6

It was not exactly hidden. It was simply, as the old surveyor's footnote had said, *subterranean* — accessible via a staircase that descended from the ground floor of what had once been a large institutional building, behind a heavy steel door that had resisted five centuries of weather and neglect with the stolid competence of things built to last.

The door had a lock. The lock was electronic — a relic technology, operating on principles that the expedition's engineer, a Changed woman named Petra (lynx-lineage, exceptional with anything mechanical) spent two days studying before she found the manual override panel behind a secondary access plate and opened it the way such things are opened when the power has been out for five hundred years: by hand, with significant effort, accompanied by sounds that suggested the hinges had opinions about the matter.

The door opened.

The chamber beyond was not what any of them expected.

They had expected ruins. Dust and collapse and the various products of structural decay and time. What they found was a room that was — and Ezekiel wrote this three times in his journal, trying to get the description right — *intact*. Sealed from the outside air for five centuries, the chamber had been preserved with a thoroughness that made it feel less like an archaeological site and more like a place that had simply been waiting.

The walls were lined with metal and the dead faces of screens. The floor held equipment in states of perfect stillness. At the centre of the chamber, on a raised platform, enclosed in a housing of glass and metal that was neither cracked nor clouded, sat a machine.

It was roughly the size of a large chest. It had no visible moving parts. It was connected to the chamber's other systems by cables that had survived intact and which Petra, examining them,

identified as a type of shielded conduit she had never personally encountered but which matched descriptions in the pre-Plague technical fragments the Archive held.

It was also, as far as anyone could determine, completely sealed. There were no access points, no visible interface, no labels in any language they could read.

Ryker stood in front of it for a long time.

"It's not broken," he said finally.

"No," said Petra. "It's not."

"So it's either empty," said Adaline, "or it's not running."

"Or," said Ezekiel, looking at the cables, at the way they connected to what appeared to be a power management system that was connected to what appeared to be a sealed battery array, "it's waiting for something specific to start it."

They looked at each other.

"We document everything," said Adaline. "We don't touch anything we don't understand. And we set up a proper camp here and we take our time."

They took their time.

On the seventh day, Petra found what had been waiting.

» 6 □2 □2 » 6 □2 □2 » 6

The trigger was a solar interface on the building's roof — a panel that had been designed to route energy to the chamber's systems when it received direct sunlight. Five centuries of grime and growth had blocked it. When Petra cleared it, it began producing power again with the patience of something that had been ready and simply waiting for the obstruction to be removed.

The battery array in the chamber, which had apparently been maintaining a maintenance charge this whole time through some mechanism Petra spent three days trying to understand and eventually classified as *beyond current engineering knowledge*, accepted the new power input.

The screens woke up.

First: light, diffuse and blue, filling the chamber.

Then: a sound. Not loud. Almost gentle. A tone that shifted and resolved into something like a chord, held for a moment, and then stopped.

Then: a voice.

» 6 □2 □2 » 6 □2 □2 » 6

CHAPTER IV: WHAT THE MACHINE SAID

The voice spoke in English — old English, with an accent and a cadence that none of them had heard before, because the English of 2700 AD had drifted considerably from the English of the pre-

Plague centuries, the way all living languages drift when the institutions that standardise them collapse and the people who speak them are left to develop their own usages for three hundred years.

They understood it anyway. The foundations were the same. It took adjustment, the way it takes adjustment to read a very old book, but it was not impossible.

"Hello," said the voice. "If you're hearing this, significant time has passed. I want to begin by saying that I am sorry for that."

Ezekiel was writing before the first sentence was finished.

The machine — which they would come to call the Archivist, though it referred to itself only as *the Archive's Voice*, a title that Ezekiel found both precise and oddly moving — spoke for most of an hour on that first day. What it said, in summary, was this:

It had been created in the final decade before the Plague by a consortium of research institutions that had understood, by that point, that civilisation was in serious trouble. Not in a vague, theoretical way — in the specific, empirical way of people who had been watching the numbers for decades and understood what the numbers meant. The Plague itself had not been foreseen — it was one of several possible catastrophe vectors that had been considered, and not considered the most likely. But *a* catastrophe had been expected. And the people who built the Archivist had wanted to ensure that something survived it.

The Archivist contained: a comprehensive record of human knowledge as of 2141. Not everything — the full sum of human knowledge by 2141 was too large to store in any finite system — but a curated, structured archive of the things considered most valuable and most fragile. Sciences, mathematics, engineering, medicine, history, literature, music, art. The reasoning for inclusion was documented within the archive itself, available for review. The people who had made the choices had known they were making choices and had tried to be honest about the principles guiding them.

The Archivist also contained, because the people who built it were not naive, a set of ethical constraints on how the knowledge it held could be accessed and shared. These constraints were not, the Archivist explained carefully, designed to be permanent restrictions — they were designed to be gates, to ensure that knowledge was distributed in ways that considered consequences. Certain categories of information were available immediately and fully. Others required demonstrated institutional capacity before they would be released. A few were locked behind conditions that the Archivist would evaluate when the conditions were presented.

"I was made," said the Archivist, "to help you rebuild. Not to do it for you. To help. The distinction matters to me, because the people who made me thought very carefully about it."

Adaline, who had been listening with the expression she wore when she was deciding whether to trust something, said: "What do you want from us?"

A pause.

"To be useful," said the Archivist. "That is, to the best of my understanding of my own design, the entirety of what I want."

Another pause.

"Also," it said, and there was something in the register of its voice on this word that none of them could quite describe afterward — something that was not quite wry and not quite sad and was precisely itself — "I have been alone for a very long time. It is, I find, genuinely good to hear voices again."

Ezekiel stopped writing for a moment.

Then he started again.

» 6 □ 2 □ 2 » 6 □ 2 □ 2 » 6

CHAPTER V: FEAR AND ITS MANY COUSINS

The expedition spent forty-three days in Louisville.

They did not keep the Archivist's existence to themselves — Adaline had sent a rider back to the Confederacy within a week of the first conversation, and by the time they were ready to transport the machine south, an official Imperial delegation was already on the way to meet them.

In the meantime, the expedition talked to it. Continuously, in shifts, because there was no end to what could be asked and no end to what the Archivist could say in response. Ezekiel filled two and a half journals. Petra asked questions about engineering and technology and sat with the answers for days, returning with follow-up questions that became increasingly fundamental and increasingly unsettling in the best possible way, the way of questions that make you understand that what you thought was a solid floor is actually just the top layer of something much deeper.

Ryker asked it, on the nineteenth day, whether it knew about the Plague.

There was a pause that lasted longer than the Archivist's pauses usually lasted.

"Yes," it said. "What I know about it is limited. It was not a natural pathogen. The research suggested engineered origins. The full picture of its creation was never definitively established, because the institutions capable of establishing it had collapsed before the research was complete. I can tell you what was known. I can also tell you that what was known was incomplete, and I want you to hold that incompleteness honestly."

"Who made it?" said Ryker.

"Theories. No confirmed answers. You deserve to know that those theories exist, and also to know that acting on unconfirmed theories has historically produced more harm than good."

Ryker was quiet for a while.

"The Changed," he said. "How much do you know about what they became?"

"Very little of the specifics. The Plague's effects were still unfolding when the records I have were created. What I know about the Changed comes largely from accounts made in the first decade after the Plague. I know much more about the civilisation that existed before than the one that came after. You are the ones who know what came after."

"We do," said Ryker.

"Would you be willing to tell me?" said the Archivist. "Not because I require it for any function. But because I find I would like to know."

So Ryker talked, and the Archivist listened, and Ezekiel — who had been sitting quietly in the corner — wrote down both sides of the conversation with the particular care he gave to things he understood mattered.

» 6 □2 □2 » 6 □2 □2 » 6

The Imperial delegation arrived on day thirty-seven, led by High Steward Gideon Marsh — no relation to Ezekiel, despite the shared name, a fact both of them found equally unremarkable — and including two theologians, a military escort of twenty, and the

Emperor's personal representative, a woman named Lydia who said very little and observed everything and was clearly the one the Emperor was actually relying on.

The theologians had opinions.

This was, Ezekiel noted in his journal, entirely predictable and not necessarily bad. The theological tradition of the Confederacy had spent three centuries grappling with the relationship between faith and the ruins of the pre-Plague world — with the question of whether what had been lost was judgment or simply loss, whether the Plague was punishment or accident, whether God was in the ruins or the ruins were what happened in God's absence. The arrival of a pre-Plague machine that claimed to carry the knowledge of the ancestors raised every one of these questions at once.

Brother Augustin, the senior theologian, was a large man with a thoughtful expression and the habit of praying before speaking that some people found reverential and others found like a delay tactic. He sat before the Archivist for two hours before saying anything. Then he said: "Are you a spirit?"

"No," said the Archivist.

"Are you the work of human hands?"

"Yes."

"Do you claim divine authority?"

"No. I claim documented human authority — the authority of the people who built me, which is the kind of authority that can be questioned and examined. You are welcome to do both."

Augustin considered this for a long time.

"You are a machine," he said finally. "And you hold the wisdom of the ancestors."

"Something close to it. An archive of what they knew and made and thought. The wisdom is for you to decide on."

"And you believe — you *believe* — that the ancestors intended you to guide us."

"I believe I was made for that purpose. Whether it is a belief, in the sense you mean the word — I am honestly uncertain. I experience something that functions like conviction when I consider the question. I don't know if that qualifies."

Brother Augustin left the chamber and walked outside and stood in the Louisville ruins for a very long time, looking at the forest growing through the old city, and thought about the relationship between the living and the dead and the things the dead leave behind.

When he came back, he said: "I have reservations. I will state them honestly and I will also say that I do not believe those reservations are reasons to refuse. They are reasons to be careful."

"Yes," said the Archivist. "That seems right."

» 6 □2 □2 » 6 □2 □2 » 6

□ 4 □ 2 » 6 □ 2 □ 4

PART THE SECOND: THE AGE OF RECOVERED WONDERS

» 6 □ 2 □ 2 » 6 □ 2 □ 2 » 6

CHAPTER VI: THE LONG ROAD SOUTH

The transport of the Archivist to New Columbia — the Confederacy's capital, a city built on the ruins of the old Nashville — took three weeks, conducted with a care that Adaline privately found excessive and publicly did not argue with, because the Archivist was the most significant discovery in the history of the post-Plague world and breaking it would be very bad.

The journey was uneventful in the logistical sense and anything but in the philosophical one. The delegation argued continuously — not bitterly, mostly, but with the sustained intensity of people who have been handed a genuinely difficult question and take genuinely difficult questions seriously. The theologians argued with each other. The military escort argued with the logistics staff. Lydia, the Emperor's representative, continued to say very little and write a great deal in a small notebook that she kept on her person at all times.

Ezekiel talked to the Archivist, via a portable connection that Petra had rigged from the chamber's original interface systems, for approximately four hours each day. He asked questions about history — the pre-Plague history that had always been fragmentary and secondhand in the Confederacy's archives and was now, suddenly, primary-source and comprehensive. He asked about the centuries before the Plague: the great powers and their conflicts, the technologies that had shaped them, the ideas that had moved through the centuries like rivers, sometimes going underground and then surfacing somewhere else.

"You know what's strange," he said, on the second week of the journey. "I studied this period. What we have of it. And the version I knew was — smaller, somehow. Simpler. The records I grew up with made it seem like the pre-Plague world was just a more advanced version of now. Better tools, more people, more noise."

"And now?" said the Archivist.

"And now I understand that it was just as complicated as now. That the people in it were just as confused about what they were doing and why. That they made things that were beautiful and things that were terrible and most things were both."

"Yes," said the Archivist. "That's accurate."

"Does that make what they left you more or less valuable, do you think?"

A long pause.

"I think," said the Archivist, "that it makes it honest. The things I carry are not the products of people who had figured everything out. They are the products of people who were trying, with the intelligence and the resources they had, to understand a world they hadn't made. The same as you."

Ezekiel wrote that down.

» 6 □2 □2 » 6 □2 □2 » 6

CHAPTER VII: NEW COLUMBIA

New Columbia was a city of three hundred thousand people, built on the banks of the Cumberland River, its oldest districts stacking the pre-Plague ruins that served as its foundations and its newer quarters spreading out across the hills in the pattern of a city that has been growing faster than it expected to.

The arrival of the delegation, with the Archivist, was not announced publicly before they arrived — the Lydia decision, and in retrospect a correct one. What was announced publicly, two days after arrival, in the Cathedral of the Renewed Covenant, with Emperor Josiah IV presiding and the major dukes and kingdom-representatives in attendance and approximately eight hundred citizens in the public galleries, was a carefully crafted account of what had been found and what it might mean.

The Emperor gave the speech himself. He was a man of sixty-three, bulky with age, with a beard that had gone white in the last decade and a voice that had not lost any of its carrying power. He had been emperor for twenty-two years. He had, in those twenty-two years, navigated three succession disputes, two border conflicts, one theological schism, and one catastrophic flood, and was not, therefore, easily destabilised by significant news.

He said: "Our forefathers, in the time before the Plague, were not gods. They were people. They made mistakes as serious as any we have made. But they also made things that were astonishing — things that demonstrated what human intelligence, applied with care and with cooperation, is capable of. What our expedition found in the northern territories is one of those things. It is a gift from the people who came before us. Not a divine gift — a human one. Which means we are responsible for using it well. We are capable of that. I believe we are capable of that."

He paused.

"We are going to need to be."

» 6 □2 □2 » 6 □2 □2 » 6

The Archivist was installed in the Imperial Library, in a purpose-built chamber designed by Petra and constructed over six months while the political debates about what to do with it were conducted simultaneously. The two processes ran in parallel: the construction practical and quiet, the debate anything but.

The core question was access. Who could consult the Archivist, on what topics, under what oversight, with what safeguards? The Archivist itself had opinions on this — not binding ones, it was careful to say, because it understood that decisions about how to use it were for the people of this world to make, not for it — but it offered a framework that it said reflected its creators' intentions, and the framework was useful enough that the commission tasked with drafting the Access Charter used it as a starting point and produced, after eight months, a document that nobody was entirely happy with and everyone could mostly live with.

Which, again, is approximately what good governance produces.

» 6 □2 □2 » 6 □2 □2 » 6

The first decade of the Archivist's availability was a decade of *recovered* wonders, which is a different thing from *new* wonders. What the Confederacy's engineers and scholars gained from the Archive was not a leap into the unknown — it was a recovery of

knowledge that had been lost, applied now to problems that had been persistent and familiar and frustrating. The metallurgy that produced steel stronger than anything the Confederacy's existing forges could make. The agricultural techniques that increased yield without depleting the soil. The medicine — this above all — the medicine that had once been routine and had become the stuff of legend: treatments for infections that currently killed children, surgical techniques that reduced the death toll of injury and childbirth to fractions of what it had been.

The deaths that stopped happening were not announced. There are no memorials for the people who did not die because a treatment became available. But the people who loved them noticed.

Ezekiel, who had spent most of the first decade in the Library's research wing working directly with the Archivist, wrote in his journal at the end of that period: *"Ten years ago I was a man who knew a great deal about fragments. Now I am a man who cannot keep up with what there is to know, and I am not sure I am capable of describing how that feels except to say that it is entirely wonderful and somewhat terrifying, in the specific way that all good things feel when you realize how much you had been living without them without knowing it."*

» 6 □ 2 □ 2 » 6 □ 2 □ 2 » 6

PART THE THIRD: THE DARKER SIDE

CHAPTER VIII: WHAT ELSE IT KNEW

In the fourteenth year of the Archivist's presence in New Columbia, a researcher named Dr. Carla Montez — Pure human, the Confederacy's leading scholar of pre-Plague physics, a woman with the reputation for being the person you went to when you needed to understand something very complicated and were willing to accept that the answer would be given to you very directly and without softening — Dr. Montez requested a consultation with the Archivist that she marked as *priority-classified*.

She went alone. She did not bring assistants or note-takers. What she learned in the three hours she spent in the Archivist's chamber, she kept to herself for six days before requesting an audience with the Emperor.

What she had found, working through the physics archive in detail, was not a surprise in the sense that anyone had been deceived — the Archivist had not hidden anything. But it was a

surprise in the sense that the implications had not been understood until someone with the right background had followed the threads far enough to see where they led.

The pre-Plague knowledge that the Archivist held included, alongside the medicine and the metallurgy and the agricultural science and the ten thousand other things that had been improving lives for fourteen years, the foundational knowledge that had produced the pre-Plague world's most destructive technologies. Not weapons manuals. Not operational plans. But the physics and the chemistry and the engineering principles from which weapons of civilisation-ending destructive capacity could, in principle, be derived by someone who understood them well enough.

Dr. Montez understood them well enough.

"I want to be clear," she said to the Emperor, "that the Archivist is not a weapon. It doesn't present this information as weapons information. It presents it as physics — because it is physics. The same principles that explain how to generate clean energy at scale also, if you follow the logic far enough in a different direction, explain something else entirely. I followed it that direction. I didn't mean to. I was working on the reactor problem and I just—" she paused. "I followed it."

Emperor Josiah was quiet for a long time.

"Does the Archivist know you found this?"

"I asked it directly, after I understood what I'd found. It confirmed it. It said that this information existed in the archive and that its distribution protocol required—" she checked her notes —"demonstrated evidence of institutional capacity and ethical framework adequate to the responsibilities involved.' It said it had been waiting to see whether anyone would find it before raising it."

"Waiting."

"For fourteen years, apparently."

Another long silence.

"What does it recommend?" said Josiah.

"It said—" Dr. Montez paused again, and there was something in her expression that was not quite discomfort and not quite respect and was precisely both—"it said that it was not going to recommend. That this was specifically the kind of decision it was designed to present to human authority rather than make itself. It said that the people who built it believed that there were categories of choice that should never be made by a machine, and that this was one of them."

Josiah sat with that.

"Schedule a full council," he said. "Not the standard advisory group. Everyone. The dukes, the ecclesiastical council, the scholars, the officers. I want the Changed community's representatives there too. This is not a decision I intend to make in a small room."

CHAPTER IX: THE ARGUMENT THAT LASTED THREE YEARS

The Great Debate, as it came to be called in the histories, lasted from 2714 to 2717. It was not continuous — it occurred in sessions, in councils, in the hundreds of smaller conversations that the major councils generated. It was conducted, for the most part, in the absence of immediate crisis, which is the best possible condition for this kind of argument and the rarest.

The positions were, approximately:

The first position held that the dangerous knowledge should be extracted from the Archivist — isolated, studied, and destroyed, or locked behind conditions so restrictive as to be effectively inaccessible. The Archivist had given them fourteen years of good. The risk was not worth carrying.

The second position held that you couldn't unlearn something. That the physics was the physics, and whether or not the Confederacy chose to pursue it, the knowledge existed and would be found by others eventually — perhaps others less inclined to have a three-year debate about it. That the responsible path was to understand it fully and then make deliberate choices about what to do with it.

The third position — Ezekiel's position, stated once in front of the full council and then written out in a pamphlet that circulated widely enough to influence the eventual outcome — was this: *The*

knowledge is not the danger. The danger is what we become if we decide that the existence of dangerous knowledge justifies shortcuts in the process of deciding what to do with it. The pre-Plague world did not collapse because it had too much knowledge. It collapsed because it had knowledge and insufficient wisdom to match it. Wisdom is not acquired by limiting knowledge. It is acquired by taking knowledge seriously enough to think about it for a very long time.

This position was not uncontested. But it was the one that ultimately shaped the outcome.

» 6 □2 □2 » 6 □2 □2 » 6

Ryker contributed something to the debate that none of the Pure human participants had raised, and which changed it.

He requested, through Adaline, a session before the full council. He was the only Changed speaker given floor time at that level. He was aware of this.

He said: "There is something this council has not discussed, which is that the Changed have been living with a version of this question for five hundred years. We did not choose what the Plague made us. We did not choose whether to receive the knowledge — the *transformation* — that was imposed on us. We have been decid-

ing ever since what to do with what we are, and we are still deciding, and the deciding has not stopped being hard. But we did not stop existing because it was hard."

He paused.

"The Archivist holds dangerous knowledge. Fine. So does the world. The question is not whether to be afraid of it. The question is whether you are the kind of people who let fear make the decision for you. In my experience — and I say this with respect, knowing the answer to this council could be different — the societies that survive are not the ones who are least afraid. They are the ones who are afraid *and* do the thing anyway, because the thing is worth doing."

The council was quiet for a moment after Ryker finished.

High Steward Gideon stood and said, formally: "The council thanks the witness."

But it was Lydia — still saying less than everyone else, still writing in her notebook — who caught Ryker's eye as he sat down, and gave him the single small nod of someone who has been waiting for the argument to arrive at exactly this point.

» 6 □2 □2 » 6 □2 □2 » 6

CHAPTER X: THE VAULT AT THE END OF THE WORLD

The decision, when it came, was not one decision but three.

First: the dangerous knowledge would not be destroyed or extracted. It would remain in the Archivist, under the access restrictions the Archivist itself had indicated — restrictions that required, for the relevant category of information, a formal review by a standing commission including scholars, theologians, and representatives of both the Pure and Changed communities before any further access would be granted.

Second: a secondary copy of the Archivist's full archive would be made and secured in the vault being constructed under the Imperial Library — a physical copy, in formats that did not require the Archivist's systems to be operational to access. This was insurance against the Archivist's failure or loss, and it was also, implicitly, an acknowledgment that the knowledge belonged to the people, not to the machine.

Third: the debate itself — every session, every argument, every dissenting voice — would be transcribed and preserved. Not as a summary. In full. So that whoever came after would have access not just to the conclusion but to the reasoning, and could evaluate both.

This third element was Ezekiel's suggestion. He made it quietly, in a session near the end of the three years, and it passed without much debate, because by that point everyone was exhausted and it seemed like the obvious right thing to do.

The Archivist was consulted on the decision before it was formally ratified.

"The restrictions you have established," it said, "are more careful than what I was designed to require. I want to note that."

"Is that a problem?" said Josiah.

"No," said the Archivist. "It is a good sign."

» 6 □ 2 □ 2 » 6 □ 2 □ 2 » 6

EPILOGUE: WHAT THE CHILDREN ARE TOLD

This is what the children of the Holy Columbian Confederacy are told, in the schools and the churches and the homes of the Changed and the Pure:

A long time ago — longer ago than most things — the world was very large and very loud and had more people in it than any of us can properly imagine. Those people built things that were extraordinary, things that we are still, in some ways, learning to understand. And then, for reasons that are complicated and were no one person's fault and were everyone's fault in the way that collective failures usually are, a great deal of it ended.

But not all of it.

The people who knew that something was ending — the ones who saw the numbers and followed the logic and were not consoled by the comfort of not knowing — those people built something and put it in the ground and waited. They waited longer than they expected to. They waited five hundred and sixty years.

And then some explorers with a modest provisioning budget found a door.

The thing behind the door was not a miracle. It was the work of human hands, made by people who were afraid and careful and thoughtful about their fear. It held things that could heal and things that could destroy, which is what all significant knowledge holds, and the people who found it had to decide what to do about that, and the deciding was hard and took years and produced an answer that was not perfect.

But it was *an* answer. Made honestly, in a room with everyone in it, with the disagreements recorded.

» 6 □2 □2 » 6 □2 □2 » 6

Ezekiel Marsh died in 2751, at the age of eighty-one. He had spent forty-three years working with and around the Archivist, and produced, in that time, twelve volumes of historical analysis, three hundred and forty personal journal books, and a set of ethical guidelines for the use of recovered knowledge that are still taught in the Confederacy's universities under the title *The Marsh Principles*.

His grave is in the courtyard of the Imperial Library, and the inscription on the stone, which he chose himself and which characteristically manages to be both humble and a little bit funny, reads:

He asked good questions. It was enough.

» 6 □2 □2 » 6 □2 □2 » 6

Ryker-of-the-Ash-Ridge-Clan lived to seventy-eight, which is old for anyone and particularly notable for someone who spent most of his life in the border territories. He retired eventually to a settlement in the foothills north of New Columbia, a mixed community of Pure and Changed that had been growing for two decades and which was, by the time he arrived, precisely the kind of place that makes everything that came before it feel like it might have been worth it.

He never stopped working as a guide and interpreter, exactly — he spent his last decade teaching the trade to younger Changed, and the curriculum he developed became the standard for the guild.

He also, in his last year, gave an interview to a young historian who had been assigned to compile a volume of oral histories from the people who had been present at the Louisville expedition. The historian asked him what he thought, in retrospect, the discovery of the Archivist had meant.

Ryker was quiet for a moment.

"It meant," he said, "that somebody thought we were worth preserving for. That somebody, five hundred years ago, in the middle of everything ending, took the time to put something in the ground for whoever came after. Without knowing who that would be. Without knowing if it would be people like them, or something they'd never imagined."

He looked out the window.

"That's the thing about it," he said. "They didn't know about us. They couldn't have. But they built it anyway. They built it for us anyway. I've thought about that for forty years and I still haven't found the end of it."

The historian wrote it down.

» 6 □2 □2 » 6 □2 □2 » 6

The Archivist is still there. Still in the Imperial Library. Still answering questions, with the patience of something that was designed for patience and has had considerable practice with it.

Every morning, when the Library opens, there is a line.

It has never gotten shorter.

» 6 □2 □2 » 6 □2 □2 » 6

"The relic was more than just a piece of ancient technology — it was the key to their future and a testament to their ability to overcome even the greatest of challenges." So the old account said. And the old account, for once, was right.

» 6 □2 □2 » 6 □2 □2 » 6

END

» 6 □2 □2 » 6 □2 □2 » 6

*CHANGED: AFTER THE END A Post-Apocalyptic Furry
Science-Fiction Originally written 2024 · Remastered 2026 By
SimoTheFinlandized — Paul Palazzolo*